The Official England Football App (The FA)

Fan Personas for a Live-Data + AI Matchday Feature

Prepared for: IBM Summer Intern Project — England Football App live-data & AI feature
Prepared by: Persona Research Agent — IBM Sports & Entertainment POV
5 August 2026

Our approach

What we looked at

We set the scope in the tool up front rather than assuming it: the UK market, a product and design purpose, fan and user personas, four to seven of them, for The Official England Football App. The brief we were given (an IBM Summer Intern project) asks for a new live-data and AI matchday feature, so the personas are built around that feature rather than the app as a whole.

Why we didn't reuse an off-the-shelf persona set

We did not reuse any ready-made or previous England-app persona set. Instead we built the personas from sourced evidence about how fans behave and what the market looks like, and then checked them against two well-known academic models of football fandom: Giulianotti's four fan types (2002) and the Sport Spectator Identification Scale (Wann & Branscombe, 1993). We used those models as a sense-check, not as the starting point.

Our approach — continued

How we organised the personas

We ordered the personas from the strongest evidence to the weakest, so the reader can see how well each one is backed up. We also separate the fans who use the feature from the people inside the FA who run it, and we flag where the audience is growing (the women's game). A few themes cut across several personas at once, such as trust in AI, reliability, spoiler-avoidance, accessibility and commercial value; we cover those separately so we don't repeat them under every persona.

The sources we used

Every number has a named, dated, clickable source, graded into three levels: top-tier (regulators, official bodies, peer-reviewed research), mid-tier (reputable commissioned studies and trade press), and lower-tier (single reviews or figures we couldn't fully trace, used only for colour). Where a strong figure comes from a company with a commercial interest, we say so (the IBM/Morning Consult AI study). Anything that is our own read rather than a sourced fact is labelled 'Inference', and where the evidence is thin we say that too.

Our approach — continued

What to keep in mind

A few honest gaps. We could not reach a dated 2025–26 YouGov figure for general interest in football, so the two 'general interest' percentages are lower-tier and drawn from Wikipedia. We don't have solid, dated data on overseas or diaspora England fans for this app, so we have not claimed a persona for them, only noted it as a question worth researching. The app-review themes are a small, early sample taken just after the relaunch. And the strongest AI-appetite figures come from a study run by a company that sells AI products. None of this stops the work, but it does set the limits on how confident we can be, which we note against each persona.

How to understand the personas

Each persona below follows the same layout, so you can compare them at a glance. Here is what each part means and how to read it.

What each section means

- Evidence strength — How well-backed this persona is by the research (Strong, Fairly strong, Limited, Structural or Hypothesis). The personas are ordered by this — strongest first — so the earlier ones rest on firmer ground.
- Who they are — A short, plain description of the person and why they behave as they do. Every claim here traces back to a stat or source.
- Key details — The demographics and attitudes that define them, each with its source. Where we could not source something, it says so rather than guessing.
- Goals — What this person is ultimately trying to achieve.
- What they're trying to do in the app — The things they actually do when using the product, described from their point of view.
- What frustrates them — The real friction and unmet needs they hit, drawn largely from reviews and other voice-of-customer evidence.
- Apps they use instead today — Where they go now to get the job done — this shows the gap the product has to close.
- Where they are — The devices, social platforms and kinds of content they use.

How to understand the personas — continued

- What the app needs to do for them — What they're trying to get done, and what that means the product should build.
- Key stats — The three or four specific figures that justify the persona. Read these as the evidence base for everything above them.
- Because the personas are ordered from the strongest evidence to the weakest, treat the earlier personas as the more dependable basis for decisions, and the later ones as directional until firmed up by the primary research suggested at the end.

How to read the stats and sources

- Every figure is followed by its source and year in brackets, e.g. "(EE/Sapio, 2026)". The full details are in the Sources list at the end.
- Sources are graded top-tier, mid-tier or lower-tier by how authoritative they are. Prefer the higher tiers; lower-tier figures are used only for colour and are flagged.
- Anything that is our own read rather than a sourced fact is labelled "Inference". Where we had no reliable data, we say so instead of filling the gap with a guess.
- Where a strong figure comes from a source with a commercial interest in the answer, we note it so you can weigh it accordingly.

Themes that cut across the personas

These apply to several personas at once rather than describing one group.

Trust in AI

Interest in AI and doubt about AI sit side by side in the same audience. 85% say AI adds value and 56% want AI insights (IBM/Morning Consult, 2025; study run by a company that sells AI products), yet UK fans rate reliability above AI and only 63% trust AI content (EE/Sapio, 2026). The takeaway for design: keep AI optional and clearly labelled ('AI-generated, checked by a person', like the BBC's pilot), and never let it get in the way of the match.

Reliability and lag

This runs through every persona and is the strongest single UK signal: 93% say a minimal delay matters most, 82% would be frustrated by a stream cutting out, and 35% already miss moments because of lag (EE/Sapio; LiveScore/YouGov, 2026). The app's own wobbles (the crash before the squad reveal, and the slow-load complaints) make this a must-have, not a testing footnote. We treat reliability as a real fan need above.

Themes that cut across the personas — continued

Avoiding spoilers

76% take steps to avoid the result and 79% are upset by a goal alert before they see it, which EE calls 'the roar before the score' (EE/Sapio, 2026). Any live-data or AI alert has to account for lag and spoilers, with timing the fan controls, or it actively harms the core experience for The Lifelong Diehard (the diehard) and The Reliability-First Sceptic (the sceptic) alike.

Accessibility and inclusion (WCAG 2.2 AA)

The Tournament-Only Casual (the casual fan) and The Lionesses-Led Newcomer (the new fan via the Lionesses) both need things to be easy to read and in plain English, and the whole feature needs to meet WCAG 2.2 AA (labels, clear focus, captions on video, motion the user can control). We treat accessibility as a design requirement across all the personas, in line with the brief and the constraints set out for us.

Themes that cut across the personas — continued

Commercial value

Each persona also carries a commercial signal. Tournaments are the FA's biggest window for sign-ups and data (The Tournament-Only Casual, the casual fan), the women's game is where the audience is growing (The Lionesses-Led Newcomer, the new fan), and The Lifelong Diehard (the diehard) and The Gen-Z Mobile Fan (the Gen-Z fan) are the base for retention and sponsor value. The reliability foundation protects all of it, because fans lost to instability are lost commercial value too.

Today

1. Playback your work to each other
2. Concise list of pain points per persona
3. The needs of the users (persona) "As a diehard fan I need..."
4. Ideation against the user needs

1. A concise list of agents you already have that have supported you in your work so far
2. As you work, assess if this is an opportunity to accelerate

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The Lifelong Diehard

Evidence: Strong

The Lifelong Diehard

The lifelong England fan who watches every match live and won't tolerate the app crashing

Who they are

The Lifelong Diehard is the heart of the app: emotionally invested, there for every England tournament match, and the fan most likely to already have the app installed. They are also the least forgiving when it fails.

What they do in the app

- Opens the app at kickoff and keeps it live for the whole match
- Checks win-probability and momentum at the big moments, and reads the context after a goal

Goals

- Feel closer to the live match, with real-time stats, win-probability and context that add to the emotion
- Never miss the moment, with no noticeable delay between the pitch and the app
- Trust what the app tells them, with clearly sourced and clearly labelled AI that never runs ahead of the broadcast

The Lifelong Diehard — continued

EVIDENCE Strong

- Follows both the England men's and, increasingly, women's matches in one place

Apps they use instead today

- FotMob (live stats powered by Opta and Opta AI), their current go-to second screen
- Sofascore Analyst (paid AI pre-match insights)
- BBC Sport and ITVX, the broadcast they watch alongside
- Content they like: live stats, win-probability, tactical breakdowns and instant replays

What frustrates them

- The app struggling under heavy load; it crashed before the World Cup squad reveal (The Sun, 2026)
- Stream lag; 35% of fans miss key moments because of it (LiveScore/YouGov, 2026)
- Spoilers; a stats alert that beats the broadcast 'roars before the score' (EE/Sapio, 2026)

Where they are

- Devices: phone as the second screen, TV as the main screen (Ofcom, 2025)
- Social: X/Twitter and WhatsApp group chats during matches (our read, based on the behaviour research)

Pain Points

- no info about key match moments eg red cards
- no player line ups
- Lack of detail: Who Scored? Who was sent off?
- Hard to tell where anything is, adds friction to experience
- More complex match analysis
- Spoilers
- Fragmentation
- not many engaging features
- What's everyone thinking? - other opinions not on the app.
- no quick match summary, key bullet points
- Too much Reading - Articles
- Lots of content on landing page, videos and shop
- Unreliable under peak load pressure
- Less interested in social/gimmick features, wants substance, not noise.
- No live broadcast
- Lack of fast updates
- Real time engagement is minimal
- Content buried under algorithmic / social-style feed instead of key info

User Needs

As a lifelong diehard, I need real-time stats, win-probability and momentum so that the data adds to the emotion at the big moments.

As a lifelong diehard, I need post-goal context and tactical breakdowns so that I understand what just happened right after it happens.

As a lifelong diehard, I need the app to open at kickoff and run live for the whole 90+ minutes without failing so that I can rely on it as my second screen every match.

Feature Ideas

Live win-probability + momentum bar - A persistent live bar that visibly swings on every key event (goal, red card, big chance)
Live Match Dashboard - A single real-time hub showing score, win-probability, momentum and headline stats together.
Illustrative graphics of stats - Heat maps, momentum curves and shot maps that visualise the numbers

Tactical breakdown replays - Auto-surfaced formation shifts, xG and pass maps at goals, half-time and full-time, explaining why the moment happened right after it did.
Head-to-head & competition context - Live context on what the result means for the group, knockout or rivalry, so each moment lands with its stakes attached.

Personal ritual view - A saved default match layout (their preferred stats and panels) that opens the same way every kickoff, becoming their reliable matchday ritual.
Key-moments Timeline - A scrubbable match timeline of goals, chances, cards and subs they can jump across at any point during the live 90.

The Gen-Z Mobile Fan

The 22-year-old who follows the match through her phone and social feeds instead of the TV

Who they are

For fans under 25, the second screen isn't really secondary. It's the main way they follow the game.

What they do in the app

- Keeps a second screen going throughout, moving between the app, social media and messaging
- Shares AI clips and stat cards, and makes predictions during the match
- Follows individual players and storylines as much as the team

Goals

- Instant, shareable moments: clips, stats and predictions worth sending to the group chat
- A feed that feels alive, with live chat, polls and predictions tuned to their team and players
- The chance to play along, with fantasy or prediction built into the live match

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The Gen-Z Mobile Fan

Evidence: Strong

The Gen-Z Mobile Fan — continued

EVIDENCE Strong

What frustrates them

- Anything slow or that can't be shared; they leave for FotMob, OneFootball or FIFA straight away
- Content they can't clip or send on
- Feeling talked at rather than played with

Where they are

- Devices: phone only for most sessions
- Social: TikTok, Instagram, WhatsApp and X; sharing is the whole point
- Content they like: short AI clips, stat cards, predictions, live chat and polls

Apps they use instead today

- OneFootball (global fan live chat)
- FIFA 2026 World Cup app (fantasy, bracket and predictor)
- TikTok, Instagram and WhatsApp (where clips travel)
- FotMob (World Cup predictor and lineup builder)

What the app needs to do

Personalised auto-highlights and stat cards; a prediction or fantasy layer during the match; live chat and polls; one-tap sharing; and an AI companion that sounds right for a mobile-native audience.

Pain Points

- not relevant/ interesting short form media
- App feels corporate rather than fan led
- Assembles their own experience — FotMob for data, BBC for analysis, Reddit/X for reaction.
- No gamification in the official app.
- Official football cedes the community and predictor layer to Reddit and Discord.
- Blogs not tailored
- Reels/ Stories feel millenial
- Most important highlights from recent match not shown
- lack of features that support the idea of a second screen

User Needs

As a Gen-Z mobile fan, I need engaging content which keeps me interacting on the app to build my profile

As a Gen-Z mobile fan, I need shared content to look native and branded when it lands in a feed or chat so that it travels well and feels worth posting.

As a Gen-Z mobile fan, I need to generate short highlight clips and stat cards in one tap so that I can send the best moments straight to my group chat while the match is still live.

Feature Ideas

Live predictions and polls: In-match "who scores next?" and "correct score?" predictions that feed a running accuracy score attached to their profile.
BeReal feature: a photo feature in a similar way to be real or the locket app, where people can take photos at a certain time
Prize opportunities - Rewards and incentives tied to predictions and quizzes that keep them coming back on match and non-match days.

Note: we have to consider things such as guardrails, age restrictions, monitoring

Updated reels and tiktoks: make the short form video content more engaging and relevant, in the corrected format, taking ideas from apps such as TikTok, instagram reels
Twitter/Threads dupe - heavily moderated allowing fans to share opinions and further supports the idea of shareable content that supports the second screen behaviour from Gen Z

Shareable stat cards - Instantly generated, branded graphics (player stat, score, win-probability swing, "moment of the match") built to send via WhatsApp, iMessage, Instagram and TikTok and other socials.

Moment capture button - A tool that grabs the last key moment as a sharable clip, no scrubbing or editing, deliverable while the match is live.

The Enthusiast

The engaged regular who follows both England teams closely and wants to understand the game, not just the score

Who they are

Genuinely engaged but not obsessive, and follows both the men's and women's teams. The largest single group of fans, and the best fit for the flagship Match Room and AI Match Companion features.

What they do in the app

- Follows live matches with a companion layer running alongside
- Reads tactical previews and post-match reaction
- Checks player ratings, looking for the context behind them
- Votes in polls and predictions, and debates the match

Goals

- Understand not just what happened but why: tactical meaning, not raw numbers
- Contextual stats and player ratings that actually mean something
- A place to debate, test and validate their own opinions
- A reason to open the app between international windows

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The Enthusiast

Evidence: Strong

The Enthusiast — continued

EVIDENCE Strong

What frustrates them

- Has to assemble their own experience: FotMob for data, BBC for analysis, Reddit and X for reaction
- The official app gives utility but no "meaning" layer
- Nothing to do in the app between tournaments

Where they are

- Devices: mobile-first, with the TV as a second screen
- Social: X, Instagram, Reddit and WhatsApp
- Segment: the Enthusiast group, around 52% of fans (Pick & Gillett); aged 25–44

Apps they use instead today

- FotMob (live data and player ratings)
- BBC Sport (analysis and reaction)
- Reddit and X (debate and community)
- OneFootball and YouTube (news and highlights)

What the app needs to do

Add a "meaning" layer, not more raw stats: tactical context and player ratings that explain why; a Match Room and AI Match Companion that turn data into insight; and reasons to keep coming back between international windows.

Pain Points

- Has to build their own matchday setup
- Jumps between apps for one match
- App tells the "what", never the "why"
- App goes quiet in non-tournament months
- Nothing to do between tournaments
- No tactical context or insight
- Player ratings with no story behind them

User Needs

As an enthusiast, I need the app to explain *why* things happened **so that** I understand the match rather than just knowing the result

As an enthusiast, I need live news, data, analysis and reaction consolidated in one place **so that** I stop having to jump between FotMob, BBC and Reddit to follow a single match

As an enthusiast, I need a reason to open the app between international windows **so that** I stay engaged in the quiet months, not just on matchdays.

Feature Ideas

AI Match Companion - An AI chat feature that explains the match when asked
Automated AI summaries - for example if there is a red card etc there will be a summary will be generated explaining why it happened

Curated reaction feed - filtered social and community reaction (the FotMob/ BBC/Reddit equivalent) surfaced in app so the conversation lives beside the data.
Polls and prediction - AI generated questions evoking diverging opinions evoking community

Breaking news and notifications - This will bring people's attention to the app
Road to the tournament tracker - A running narrative of the emerging squad picture, so the quiet months feel like a story building toward the game

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The Tournament-Only Casual

The once-a-tournament viewer who ignores football until a Euros or World Cup knockout, then wants to catch up fast

Who they are

This is the biggest and most changeable audience: the fan who ignores football for months, then joins 18–30m others for an England knockout. Their interest is low most of the year and spikes hard during tournaments. They don't want depth.

- Likely to register or download around a specific big match

Goals

- Feel included and informed without needing to know much beforehand
- Simple answers at a glance: the score, the key moments, and who's who
- Not feel swamped by stats or jargon

What they do in the app

- Opens the app a few times during a match to check in
- Wants a plain-English 'what just happened, and what does it mean' read

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The Tournament-Only Casual

Evidence: Fairly strong

The Tournament-Only Casual — continued

EVIDENCE Fairly strong

What frustrates them

- Too much data; dashboards built for diehards put them off
- Trouble logging in or signing up at the very moment they're keen (App Store reviews; thefa.com, 2026)
- Jargon and stats that aren't explained

What the app needs to do

A simple 'match companion' mode that explains things in plain English; one-tap sign-up with no friction; a live score and context at a glance; and depth that only appears if they ask for it.

Apps they use instead today

- BBC Sport and ITVX (their main way in)
- WhatsApp family and friend groups
- Google (quick score checks)

Where they are

- Devices: phone now and then, with TV as the main screen
- Social: light, mostly WhatsApp and Facebook (our read)
- Content they like: plain-English summaries, a simple live score and context, and short explainers

Pain Points

- Nothing to do in the app between tournaments
- Easily lost between tournaments.
- A discovery gap between tournaments and the domestic game.
- app doesn't change while a match is going on
- Most vulnerable to registration walls and post-tournament drop-off.
- At-home / second-screen is exactly the experience excluded fans rely on most.
- Hard to find where matches are broadcast locally.
- no notifications when something important happens during a match
- Lack of beginner friendly explanations
- Blog posts are the first thing seen - daunting for users with less advanced knowledge
- Lack of social aspect, especially given they are purely there to socialise
- More Interactive features to show where England places on the league
- No eyecatching stats - there needs to be stats that everyone should know/see
- Login/sign-up friction at the exact moment they are motivated to join

User Needs

As a tournament-only casual, I need the score, key moments and who's who at a glance so that I feel included and informed in seconds.

As a tournament-only casual, I need an easy way to find where the match is broadcast locally so that I can actually watch it.

As a tournament-only casual, I need someone to break down jargon and advanced ruled.

Feature Ideas

At a glance match card - A single card showing live score, match clock and a simple language moments timeline (goal, red card, penalty) with no stats or jargon.
Tappable player cards - a card with photo, position and a one-line on who they are and stats about them, eg goals per season

Catch me up recap - A 30-second ai generated summary operable by button in a live match center. ("here's what you've missed") so the Casual late arriver is instantly up to speed.

Notifications before the game : **"Match in 30 minutes, Watch on XYZ"**

Beginner-friendly explainers - Inline "what does this mean?" tooltips for offside, xG and qualification rules, so jargon never swamps a casual viewer.

Small Icon for the AI Match companion - This will pop up when a slightly advanced commetary or situation has happened nudging this user to use the AI feature

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The Lionesses-Led Newcomer

Evidence: Fairly strong

The Lionesses-Led Newcomer

The fan who got into England through the Lionesses and wants the women's game treated as the main event

Who they are

The fastest-growing England audience.

What they do in the app

- Follows the Lionesses' matches and players, and explores the men's game too (75% follow both)
- Engages around tournaments and standout WSL and international moments
- Enjoys discovering the players and the stories

Goals

- One home that treats England women's football as the main event
- The same live data and AI for the women's game as for the men's
- Room to go deeper into players, storylines and fixtures as their interest grows

What frustrates them

- The women's game being treated as an afterthought or given thinner data
- Gaps between what the men's and women's coverage offers

The Lionesses-Led Newcomer — continued

EVIDENCE Fairly strong

- The same sign-up friction as everyone else, which puts off newer fans

Where they are

- Devices: phone first
- Social: Instagram and TikTok, led by players and stories
- Content they like: player stories, live data for women's matches, and explainer and companion content

Apps they use instead today

- BBC and ITV (women's finals)
- Sky (WSL rights)
- Instagram and TikTok (following the players)

What the app needs to do

The same live-data and AI features for the women's game as the men's; discovery led by players and stories; depth that grows with the fan; and women's fixtures given equal billing in the matchday feature.

Pain Points

- very heavily focused on the mens
- missing data
- Defects to BBC and Reddit (r/lionesses, r/WomensSoccer) for "where to watch" and contribution.
- Content imbalance versus the men's team.
- Official content assumes a Mens team
- Women's game treated as an afterthought

User Needs

As a Lioness fan I need content that tailors to my team.

As a Lionesses-led newcomer, I need to follow the Lionesses and explore the men's game in one place so that the 75% of us who follow both are served together.

As a Lionesses-led newcomer, I need women's fixtures given equal billing in the matchday feature so that official content stops assuming a men's team by default.

Feature Ideas

Tailored notifications - Lionesses alerts: kickoff, goals, squad announcements, ticket drops, etc. tuned to the team and players the user actually follows.

Neutral standard and personalisable homepage - The feed leads with both mens and lioness content given equal position until the user expresses a preference via setting to change their content.
Cross-over discovery - "If you follow the Lionesses, you might like..." recommendations that bridge the women's and men's games in one seamless experience.

Equal billing matchday layout - A matchday feature that presents women's and men's fixtures with identical prominence, styling and depth, with no "default team" baked into the design.